Backpack Folder Map

A simple color-code system, so paperwork stops living in a black hole.

HOW TO USE THIS SHEET

Buy four cheap two-pocket folders (or reuse last year's) and a bunch of sticky labels. Label and color-code them like this sheet, then fill in the blanks with the real names from your child's school. The rule that makes it work: **papers only move right to left**. They arrive in TO SCHOOL, get handled, and end up in HOME when they have nowhere to go. Empty the folders every school night on the checklist spot (sheet 1 covers weeks one to two; this map covers the whole year).

FOLDER	COLOR / LABEL	WHAT GOES IN IT
TO SCHOOL (left pocket)	_____	Papers headed back: forms, signed notes, teacher replies — the "outgoing mail" of the backpack.
HOME (right pocket)	_____	Anything that stays home after the nightly empty-out.
MONEY & FORMS	_____	Lunch money (see the lunch card, sheet 6), book-order cash, anything with a **due date**. Check it every night.
KEEP ALL YEAR	_____	Schedules, login cards, class list, report cards — cleared into a home binder at each break (sheet 8 finishes the year).

NIGHTLY BACKPACK EMPTY-OUT — READ IT IN ORDER, IT TAKES TWO MINUTES:

☐ 1. Lunchbox out, wipe it ☐ 2. WATER BOTTLE emptied (tomorrow's you says thanks) ☐ 3. Paper from HOME pocket, glanced and sorted

☐ 4. Sign / fill anything in MONEY & FORMS ☐ 5. Papers back into TO SCHOOL ☐ 6. Homework into HOME, then into kid's homework spot

WHERE THE BACKPACK LIVES AFTER SCHOOL: _____ **SIGNED FORMS WAIT IN THIS FOLDER:** _____

WHERE HOMEWORK HAPPENS: _____ **WHERE LIBRARY BOOKS WAIT:** _____

WHERE THE LUNCH (SHEET 6) AND SICK DAY (SHEET 7) CARDS LIVE: _____

Tip: if a folder is destroyed by October, that was its destiny. Replace it and move on. Cheap folders, zero guilt.